

HOW TO PLANT

To plant your Sitka Spruce, you'll have the better chances by planting it among debris (such as fallen logs or stumps). They are also slightly shade tolerant so you can save sunnier spots for other plants.

These trees also grow best along the pacific coast, but can grow anywhere West of the Cascades, all the way up to Alaska.

Sitkas can grow to heights of about 300 ft and a width of about 20 ft. Plant it about 15 ft away from buildings and power lines. And about 30 ft away from underground utilities as these trees will grow roots that spread out to help provide more stability as it grows.

These trees are picky when it comes to the environment they grow. They need a lot of minerals to grow strong, so is recommended to grow among forest debris.

Avoid the errors shown on the right. Graphics by Department of Natural Resources.

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Too shallow



Turned up roots



Tangled roots



Too deep



Rock



Air pocket

ABOUT

Ruta Verde Sustainability is a 501(c)3 nonprofit focused on the research of Indigenous sustainable practices such as Agroforestry, which mixes agricultural crops with native trees and shrubs to provide environmental and economic benefits:

ENHANCED BIODIVERSITY

Different plants invite different beneficial insects, bacteria, and fungi which build healthy soils

PROTECT WATER

Trees and plants with larger roots and increased biomass helps to hold and cleanse water.

HEALTHIER FOOD

Increased water retention and perennial root systems provide food that is more nutritious and more resilient

Agroforestry is one of the many techniques Indigenous people developed over centuries of interacting with the local environment. By learning and implementing these lessons into our modern practices we can create healthy and sustainable futures. If you'd like to support our work, check out our website, rutaverde.org



Gracias



SITKA SPRUCE (PICEA SITCHENSIS)



The second tallest of the pine family, the Sitka Spruce is a coastal tree that is able to grow in spaces that deal with ocean spray which earns it the name of coastal or tideland spruce. This tree is also one of the strongest strength-to-weight ratios which helps the plant to survive the coastal winds, and it also makes for great instrument material for pianos, and string instruments.

TREE FACTS

Scientific name:
Picea sitchensis
Family: Pinaceae
Genus: *Picea*
Division: Pinophyta
Kingdom: Plantae

Growth rate: 2' - 3' per year



SEED HARVESTING

The optimal time to collect Sitka Spruce seeds is from mid-August to mid-September, when the cones are just ripe enough to avoid seed loss. You'll want to grab those cones as they're turning from green to brown, before they hit the ground. Stratification of 30 days will help the plants develop but not necessary.



FUN FACTS

Sitka translated to Mother Tree as Indigenous people saw it as a female protector and Guardian. Able to grow from Western Oregon all the way up to Alaska, where it is named the state tree. This tree always grows quickly like Douglas Fir and is often used for reforestation efforts, but unlike the Douglas Fir than can live up to 1500 years, Sitkas live to about 800 years, with an average of 400 years due to their susceptibility to disease.

ROLE IN THE FOREST

Sitka Spruces are designed to grow on coastal areas, helping to provide erosion control against ocean winds by developing large and strong root systems. These trees are able to tolerate the saltwater spray from the ocean and help to keep our coastal temperate forests healthy.

USES

The tree's wood is specially sought after for the building of instruments and other uses that require strong but light wood such as airplanes, ships, and the blades for electrical wind farms.

The needles are also edible, used to make a tea that is referred to as invigorating. Additional, some brewers use the Sitka flavors to make Spruce Beer.

Indigenous Peoples use Sitka spruce in winter dance ceremonies and for medicinal purposes. The inner bark is a good source of vitamin C and can also work as a laxative, and the pitch can be eaten or applied as a salve to burns, boils and other skin ailments.

Indigenous peoples use softened pitch to waterproof boats and fishing gear, and they use the roots to create beautiful, water-tight hats, baskets, ropes, twine and fishing lines.

